

PHIL 201 Philosophy of Sex and Love

Essay Assignment 1

General Instructions

Write a brief essay on the topic given below. The essay should be no more than 3 double-spaced pages in length with 12-point font and standard margins (900-1000 words by computer word count).

Due Date: The assignment is due on **Wednesday, June 10, at 11:59 pm ET**.

Submission:

You must submit your work online through the Essay Assignment 1 folder in the LEARN Dropbox. Please note carefully that only ONE file will be accepted to the Dropbox. Therefore, you must not use the Dropbox to store drafts or otherwise incomplete versions of your work. Use only [supported browsers](#) to submit your work. See below for detailed instructions on preparing online submissions and submitting them to the LEARN Dropbox.

Your name should NOT appear anywhere on the assignment: Refrain from including your name on the front page, in the headers or footers, in the file name, or anywhere else on/in the assignment. This helps to ensure that your work is graded fairly. However, the following pieces of information MUST be on the front page of your assignment:

- Student ID Number
- Course Name and Number
- Assignment Number ("Essay Assignment 1")
- Date

Late policy:

Late essays will be penalized at the rate of 10% per day late. See the "Late / Missed Content" section of the course outline for further information on late policies. See also the "Administrative Policies" section regarding procedures for declaring absences and providing relevant documentation.

Note on plagiarism:

Passing off the work of others as your own constitutes plagiarism and is a serious offence. All suspected cases of plagiarism are referred to the Associate Dean's office. See the University of Waterloo's webpage on [Academic Misconduct](#) for important information on plagiarism and other academic offences. (See below for instructions on appropriate methods of citation for your essay.)

Important note on Generative AI: The use of generative artificial intelligence tools—for example, Chat GPT—at any stage in the production of content for your submission is ***not permitted*** and will be open to the charge of academic misconduct (with associated penalties) under [UW Policy 71](#).

Topic

Patricia Marino and Martha Nussbaum agree that there are conditions under which sexual

objectification may be morally unproblematic. However, Marino disagrees with Nussbaum on what those conditions are. In your view, what are *the most significant differences* between Nussbaum's and Marino's respective accounts of the conditions under which sexual objectification would be unproblematic? Outline those differences and then evaluate the debate. Who has the more persuasive position, Nussbaum or Marino, and what is it about the position you favour that *makes it* more persuasive?

Citations

- Use in-text references of the (author, page #) format *whenever you directly quote or paraphrase, or otherwise represent ideas from assigned course articles*.
E.g., (Nussbaum, p. 271)
E.g., (Marino, p. 348)
- References to lecture content should be given by the course author's name and the section number of module page cited.
E.g., (Marino, Mod. 3.1)
- Since your essay principally concerns course readings, separate Works Cited will not normally be required. However, if you choose to refer to outside sources (i.e., sources other than course readings), these must be properly documented and included in a Works Cited list at the end of the essay. ***Please note that consultation with outside sources is unnecessary and may even prove to be a distraction.***

Guidelines on Essay Content

The essay assignments for this course are designed as an opportunity for you to think about, and argue for, your own response to philosophical issues raised in the course. Typically, assignments of this sort confront you with two challenges:

First, since the assignments will focus on ideas presented in the course texts, one challenge is to find clear and succinct ways of **summarizing ideas and arguments presented by authors from the texts**. In doing so, it is important that you be clear and fair in how you present these ideas and arguments. It is also important that you make the effort to summarize the views of others in your own words. You can use brief quotations when it is important to stress how an author has actually stated a specific point, but don't let the use of quotations, or even close paraphrases, come in the way of your own effort to encapsulate what the author is getting at.

The second challenge is that of **critically evaluating the ideas and arguments your essay focuses upon**. This is the most important task, since expressing and defending your own judgement on a philosophical issue is the main point of writing an essay in the first place. In developing your own critical perspective, it is important to provide your own argument — i.e., your reasons for the judgement you arrive at — whether you are defending or opposing the author(s) you are discussing. It may be that your critical reflections lead you to propose alternative conclusions to those of the author(s) your essay focuses upon. This is fine, but here too it is important that you give reasons (i.e., an argument) for your conclusions. It is also important to be aware of possible criticisms of your own views and, as far as possible, to show how such criticisms might be addressed.

The essays for this course are not research essays. It is therefore strongly advised that you devote most of your attention to the relevant readings from the course texts, rather than trying to find additional sources (either in the library or on the web). From time to time, you may wish to allude to facts in the world that aren't discussed in the readings. This is fine, but be aware that you may need to include a citation to a relevant source if the fact(s) you allude to are not common knowledge (i.e., things that you could reasonably expect any educated reader to be aware of). In general, it is important that you provide appropriate citations for any reading material that informs your discussion, **including course material**.

Essay topics distributed during the term will contain explicit instructions on how to cite your sources, and you should attend to these instructions carefully.

Here are some additional pointers for you to keep in mind as you work on the essay assignments:

- Your paper should have a title. It should also include page numbers.
- Have a clear thesis that you argue for. Do not merely summarize or write a report. Tip: It is useful to use the following phrase in introducing your thesis: "*In this paper, I argue that X*", where X stands for the thesis you will be arguing for.
- State your thesis early on, argue for it, then give a brief conclusion at the end of the paper.
- Be sure to argue for your claims, instead of stating personal opinions without justification. Arguing for your claims means giving reasons and justifications.
- Be as methodical, organized, clear and concise as you can. Make it easy for the reader to know exactly what you mean.
- When discussing texts and authors, be sure you bring out the most important points they make on the topic under discussion. You won't be able to summarize everything they say, so be prepared to make some judgements about what is most important and what can be left aside for the purpose of your essay.
- Read charitably: when describing or criticizing the views of others, present those views as strongly as you can — that is, make them seem as plausible and important as possible, even if the ultimate goal of your discussion is to point out problems with those views.
- For improvements to organization, clarity, style, etc., try reading your paper out loud to a friend; listen to your own sentences, and ask what your friend understood the main point to be.
- Thinking about philosophy is challenging, but it can also be a lot of fun when you approach it with some interest and energy. Have fun!

The essay assignments in this course will be graded for clarity, organization, originality and quality of ideas, writing skills, quality of argumentation, and significance of the thesis.

Guidelines for Submitting Papers Online

- Only the following file types will be accepted: **Rich Text Format (.rtf); Microsoft Word format (.doc or .docx).**
- Be sure to save your assignment in an appropriate folder or on your desktop for easy retrieval.
- Ensure that the name of your file does not include special characters such as symbols or punctuation (e.g., \ / : * ' , ? " < > |). Such characters may cause problems with the upload.
- You will only be able to upload **one file per assignment**. Please combine all documents into one file. Check to make sure that you are submitting the correct file.
- Do not zip your files.

How to Submit Assignments Online Using a LEARN Dropbox

- Click on the **Add a File** button within the Dropbox and select **My Computer**.

- Click on the **Upload** button to look for your assignment file on your computer. You can also drag and drop the file from your computer to the upload area.
- Find and select your assignment file and click **Open**.
- Upload your assignment by clicking the **Add** button. When the file has finished uploading, the name of your file will appear under the **Files to submit** area.
- Click the **Submit** button. If you do not click the Submit button, the file will not be uploaded.
- After submitting your file, a confirmation message will appear. This message will include a link to your submitted file. **Please ensure that your submission is visible on this page.**
- If your submission is successful, you will receive an **Email Confirmation Receipt** sent to your @uwaterloo.ca email address. If you do not receive an Email Confirmation Receipt, please double-check your submission and re-submit if necessary.

If you are having difficulties uploading your files, please try the following:

- Check the [computer requirements](#).
- Ensure that your file name does not contain any special characters (e.g., \ / : * ' , ? " < > |) and delete any spaces in the file name.
- Ensure that there is an extension at the end of your file name (e.g., Assignment1.doc).
- If you are still experiencing difficulties after checking the above items, please contact [Technical Support](#).

Assignment Return: Your graded assignment will be returned to you through the Dropbox. Review the graded file for feedback on your work.